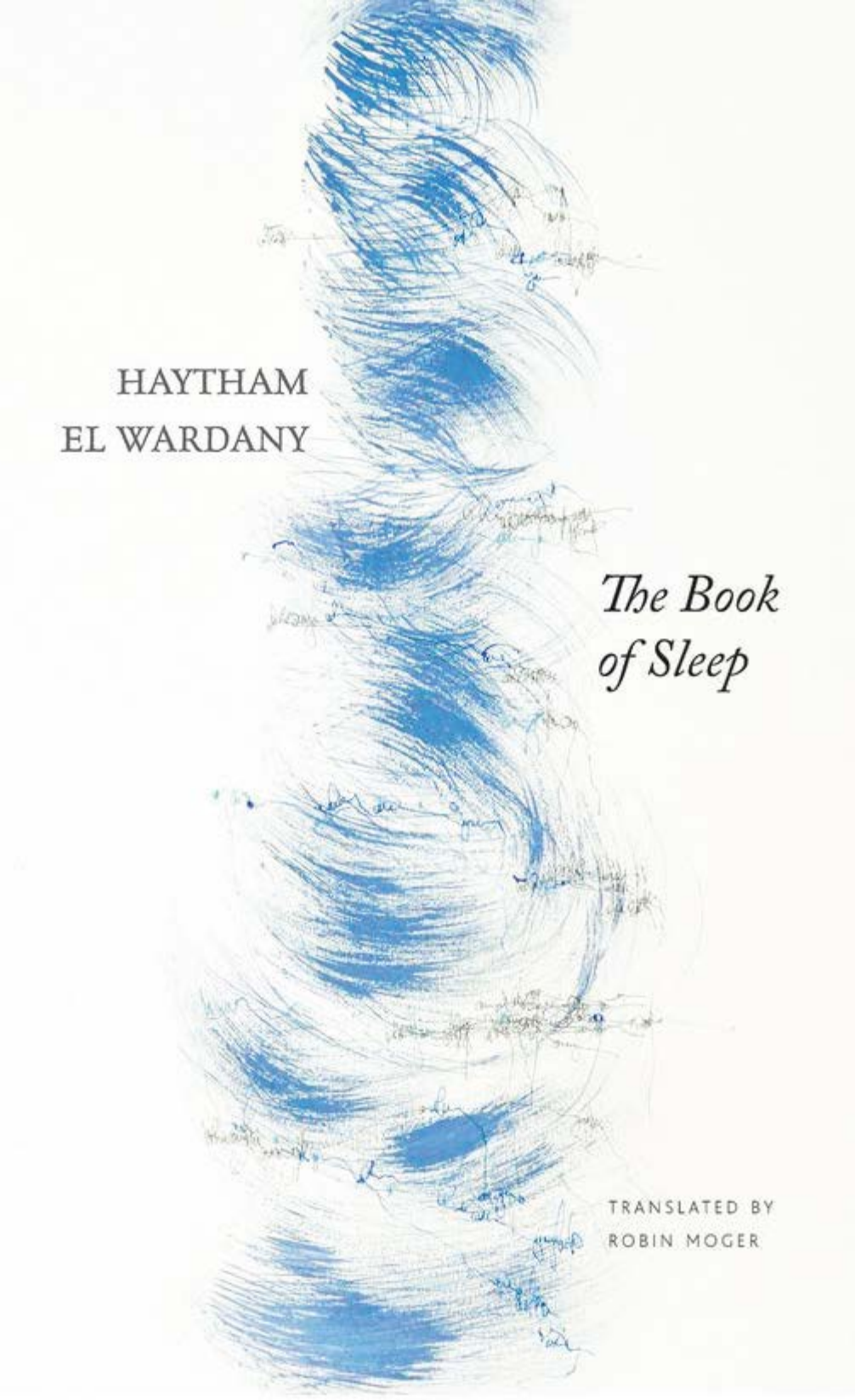




HAYTHAM
EL WARDANY

*The Book
of Sleep*

TRANSLATED BY
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The Arab List

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Introduction

The sleeper's heartbeat can be timed and brainwaves plotted. Sleep can be reframed, portrayed as a psychological stage on which the tragedy of Oedipus plays out night after night. Scientific experiments might dissect phenomenal sleep and theories pick through it but sleep itself stays out of reach. It inhabits a distant, darkened corner. It participates in reality from afar, with no desire to come closer. Those who are closer cannot understand what this means, that reality can be participated in from afar. They see it as no more than stark contradiction and work incessantly to keep sleep present in their waking, which is when they look at it, brushing aside the right it reasserts each night to be present in absence. Sleep requires this work, then, because only work makes the effort to reach out and touch sleep's faint trace without trying to make it present or to convert it into an object of inquiry. Work does not seek to quantify sleep or dissect it; it wants to go to it, to visit it in the distant place where it is found. And just as sleep hands itself to work, so work gives itself to sleep, each proceeding towards the other like head meeting pillow. Because work needs sleep. Initially, work appears on the horizon as a distant possibility. The writer bends its way, trying to reach it and make it real. It becomes more unattainable. The writer persists, striving to bring it into the light. It recedes further. The tighter the grip of the force which seeks to shape it, the more impossible work becomes, and so the writer perseveres, unpicking the problems that confront him until weariness fells him and he is overcome by sleep—and at last, the potentiality of work is renewed. Only when the writer surrenders himself to sleep and the force which grips work is broken does work become

possible once again. Before, work was only an image of that force; now it can return to itself. Work does not want to be made, it wants to happen, and in order to happen it must find a space for itself on the margins of the force that shaped it. Work seeks sleep because sleep is open to contradiction, to de-partition, and it can be at once present and absent, manifest and hidden, at the centre and on the fringe. Sleep and work need one another. The first wants something which it can approach without waking it, the second wants something which can forget it, and make it possible once again.

The Kingdom of Things

The room is full of its things. There is a small desk by the door and a lamp beside the bed. There is a suitcase against the wall and a flowerpot on the window frame. In the desk drawer there is a passport and a marriage certificate. In the dresser drawer, a gold earring, a bracelet. A bright shirt has been carelessly tossed over the chair and abandoned on the floor is a sock pulled inside out. We leave all this behind us and are pulled towards the abyss called sleep. There, for a moment, time stops, and we imagine that we have gone somewhere, somewhere else, but even as we arrive we are cast back into the room itself, and this time not as a presiding force but as one thing among its many, the thing which we've become in sleep propelled by irresistible sympathy towards the other things and seeping now, bit by bit, onto the pillow, then onto the bed, then out into the room. And just as we are transformed into things during sleep, so the things in our rooms transform into beings. They are not what we know. They lose their passivity and gradually return to themselves. No longer objects and implements, they are now bodies through which a hidden, inner motion flows. They are our things which we resemble and which resemble us, and the deeper we fall into sleep the more we settle into them, or they into us, or all of us together into the room. In the fraternity of sleep, we do not encounter things along the lines of power but rather in the primordial matter, in the heart of its becoming. The flood of its first forms runs through us, and in us beats a pulse as old as the universe.

The Reassured

Sometimes, the social space ceases to be an arena for negotiation and conflict, a forum for exchange and dialogue, and another, hidden aspect of the social experience emerges. Shared silence. Sleep on public transport and in public squares, in lecture halls or at work, is a twofold rejection of the social act because it takes place, not in our private bedrooms, but at the very heart of traditional sites of social interaction. The sleeper at work steps away from their work; the sleeper on public transport stops watching the roadside advertisements; the sleeper in the public square abstains from engagement. Sleep taps the public sphere with its wand and transforms it from a place of mediation and competition into one of silence and absence. Silence and absence are no longer a private matter but a collective act. Yet in its social dereliction, sleep does not make the public sphere into a place of detachment and indifference but one—how strange!—of confidence and reassurance. At the very heart of the social disruption which sleep effects, can be discerned a renewed faith in the other. One without any identifiable cause. The sleeper in public places does not bargain or compete with the other, he does not form alliances or engage. He places himself in his hands. Lays bare before him his weakness, his insignificance, his ineffectuality. Sleep in public, then, is a declaration of faith in the other, and the other in question, the other next to whom the sleeper sleeps with such assurance, is not one person but a whole community of the unknown: strangers who are there by chance; a community whose members the sleeper has no desire to know. Reassured by their collective presence, he allows himself to become, like them, a stranger.

The Principle of Hope

We bid the world farewell knowing that it will endure without us. Nothing will come to end on our account; nothing will be affected by our absence. We have done all we could but our actions are destined to remain unfinished. Now see the day, gone so soon. We bid farewell to the world and we lay our heads on our pillows. But we are not sad. We are full of hope. There, in the heart of the darkness, we find a hope quietly flourishing, growing stronger and sturdier the further we push on into the night. A hope of waking. A hope that the dark will roll away. A hope in tomorrow; in a new beginning. A hope that when we open our eyes the next day everything will be as it should be. This hope ripens inside the night like a fruit. It swells in the dark; grows sweeter the blacker the night. This fruit is sleep's gift, for sleep is the true exercise of hope; a long training in emancipation and freedom. But on what does this hope rest? On a boundless faith in the unknown, once fear in the unknown has been overcome. A faith in absence, after we have surrendered ourselves to absence. A boundless faith, in a world to which we bid farewell each night, certain we are in safe hands. A faith that arises each time we lose our control over the world; when we entrust the world with our selves, to do what it wants with them. The hope that resides in sleep is not, therefore, like any other. It is the principle of hope. It does not arise out of a desire for a given object but from the greater desire which transcends all objects: the desire to cross to the other bank and embrace the unknown.

Waste

History does not wait for the sleepers to wake. It is written by the waking, and only them. After all, what in all the hours of sleep is so worth recording that the history books should take it into account? Surplus hours, useless and unproductive. But these hours do not wither and fade as a surplus should. Night on night their numbers swell, become a great host. Yet a host quite unlike any other, because no matter how numerous, these hours never acquire any mass worth mentioning, nor presence. They are forever hovering in the background: ineffectual, ignored, a neglected excess that everyone knows about and no one speaks of. The years pass and sleep endures, a fine dust strewn over the pages of history, perhaps clumping here in the form of a dream, or as a vision there, but otherwise kept outside the lines, a soul which haunts everything which has not been written. In the face of this neglect, sleep offers a response: repetition. Like all essentially real things, sleep knocks the ball back night after night, creating from repetition a law. Every evening it returns to us with all its passivity and insignificance and failure, and restates its insistence on unending futility, reaffirms its affiliation with all the griefs of the past. Expelled from history, sleep neither advances nor retreats, it does not produce and it does not accumulate, and yet, despite this, it is the line beyond which progress's arrow cannot pass. What can man-in-history possibly do, confronted by this daily waste? What can he do with all these hours of sleep? Can he cut them down? Forget them the moment he wakes? Press them down, one on top of the other, into a flaky pastry he then eats? Wander through them like autumn leaves? Abandon himself to them? What can he do?

Zero Point

Does sleep precede waking or does it follow? Is waking born from sleep or does it die there? Is sleep the condition for waking or vice versa? The question of primacy seeks an origin for what follows it, a zero point from which all things begin. But what if there was no such point? What if sleep and wakefulness were not a pair of states which pass in succession through us, one springing from the other, but two intertwined bodily experiences? One experience in other words, in which the self is barricaded into the body and the body is one object among many others in the world. And then another, in which the body hides no self inside it but maintains instead a permanent openness through which it becomes one with the world. In this picture, sleeping and waking are not associated through alternation, nor do they take place separately: they pulse simultaneously through a single body, a body formed of continuous and interpenetrating experiences which will never reach a conclusion as long as the body remains alive. Experiences the body never stops entering into and never knows where in this world they will lead.

Who Is the Sleeper?

A limb severed from the whole? A single self? A small group at rest? Those who are awake never stop belonging to a social body, even when spatial or temporal absence separates them from the body's other limbs. The traveller, for instance, remains part of the group he left behind, no matter how long or far his journey takes him. And the same with the sleeper who, despite his absence in sleep, also never stops being part of the social body. The difference between the waking and the sleeper is that the former tends to preserve his social body and reaffirm its boundaries, while the latter moves to blur the body, to muddy its purity by opening it to others. The absent individual is not a hole in an ordered social body but rather a line along whose length the whole body moves, propelled by its connections with strange bodies towards inarticulacy. And the sleeper's dreams are the moment of this propulsion, in which one body is opened to others—they are inarticulate babblings, at once personal, social and political; they are the collision of multiple desires, of clashing streams that run in all directions. Each sleeper is an inarticulate social body, a city broken free of its map, its districts and streets run together, fit not for habitation but perpetual displacement.

Who Is the Sleeper?

A limb severed from the whole? A single self? A small group at rest? If sleep is the clearest manifestation of individual agency—an act that admits of no outside participation in its performance—then the essence of sleep, without which it must remain incomplete, is the self discarding its self. Which is to say that in its most organic act, the act closest to its own will, the self does not turn in on itself but voluntarily casts off its agency, as though it may only attain itself by leaving its self. Maybe this is why we need sleep, in order to apprehend that our selves are a small group of which the self is just a part. Here, within the state of sleep, we understand just how impoverished this question is, of whether the sleeper is an individual apart or part of a collective: it is the question of a waking state which looks out at the world from the cave of the self. What the state of sleep proposes is that there is no individual as distinct from a group, and no group made up of individuals. There are only groups. There are big groups and little groups, human groups regulated by authority, groups which humans share with the dead, and trees. Through the act of sleep, which brings the self out of itself, the sleeper becomes a small, permanently open community, a group without a fixed centre. And here, even if it never ends up joining the ranks of a larger group, the individual is no abstract mathematical coordinate but a single group astir, in a state of action.

Who Is the Sleeper?

A limb severed from the whole? A single self? A small group at rest? At the heart of every group is a wound which will not heal, its pain renewed each time some part of it falls away. Yet always the group will take the side of what remains visible, will privilege the living over the dead and place its hope in the future: the hope that the wound will heal with time. The group sees in itself a history of renewal and development, averting its gaze from a parallel history of loss and disconnection. But sleep does not look away; it turns to face this parallel history head on and, impelled by the catastrophe of loss, is drawn to what is visible no longer. The eye of the sleeper is fixed on the departed; all he sees of the community to which he belongs is the absent part, the cracks and breaks which spread and widen day after day. The group to which the sleeper belongs is a lost group, marching towards the open wound. It is not cohesion that holds them together, nor looking forward, but a weakness, a looking backward. Sleep does not seek to bring ease to this wound buried in the heart of every group. It wants only to approach it.

Your Voice

If it is true that power speaks the language of your thoughts and desires, that it is no longer a monster that you fight outside yourself but one that inhabits you and speaks in your voice, then your silence is the simplest way to negate its harm. Silence is the moment in which the desire for action encounters an understanding of its own contradictions. But it is not enough. The sleeper's silence may constitute the most absolute and powerful refusal to participate in the forming of a position or in the performance of an action, but in this it is still subservient to power: the refusal to take a position is, in the end, a position in itself. The only truly damaging blow against the language of destruction is delivered by the inarticulate voice. The sleeper's incomprehensible mutterings deliver the sleeper from power's dominion and confound its language. The sleeper speaks but says nothing; he only liberates a stream of words. He does not look for sentences to illuminate meaning but fragments to make it more obscure. His language is disintegrated, inverted. It does not issue from a mouth behind which stands a self. Its pieces take shape like clouds in the sky.